

The Four Goals

A workbook for setting goals
that survive contact with real life



Process goal



What actions will you take?

How much are you willing to invest in the process? • How committed are you, one to ten? • If it isn't a ten, what would make it a ten?

The smallest unit of your goal — the piece that today can be judged by. A trigger and an action, in that order. Naming the moment is what makes it work: the situation makes the decision, instead of your willpower on a wet Tuesday.

THE SENTENCE

When _____, I will _____.

Examples

- When my alarm goes at 6:15, I'm in the pool by 6:45 — no decision gets made after the alarm.
- When I close my laptop at the end of the day, I write 300 words before I open anything else.
- When a call ends, I write the follow-up before I stand up.

Naber's version

When I train for an hour, I come out one thousandth of a second faster than I went in.

THE TEST

I can tell by tonight whether I did it.

"More often," "regularly" and "when I can" are not process goals. They're wishes with a frequency attached.

Performance goal



What will you deliver?

What will it mean to you to deliver that? • What will it be like — what will you see, hear, feel? • Is this standard yours, or did someone hand it to you?

The level you are operating at, that you can deliver whatever anybody else does. Specific and difficult goals beat “do your best” across hundreds of studies — because “do your best” has no edge, so there is never a moment where you find out.

THE SENTENCE

By _____, I will be operating at _____.

Examples

- By March, I run 5k in under 24 minutes.
- By the end of Q2, I'm holding twelve paid conversations a month at my full rate.
- By June, I have a manuscript I'd be willing to hand to an editor.

Naber's version

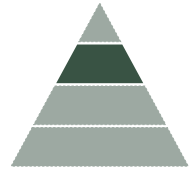
By the 1976 Games, I will be swimming the 100m backstroke four seconds faster than I swim it today.

THE TEST

Nobody else's brilliant day can take this from me.

If a competitor, a panel, a market or an algorithm has a wonderful day and you still hit it — it's a performance goal. If not, you've written an end goal and given it a different name.

End goal



What are you aiming to achieve?

When are you going to achieve it? • What are the benefits for you? • Who else will benefit, and in what way?

The outcome you actually care about, and the one you do not control. It gives the whole structure a direction — but make it your only goal and it can produce exactly one verdict when you miss. The second line below is what prevents that.

THE SENTENCE

By _____, _____.

Mine to deliver: _____ Not mine: _____

Examples

- Signed with an agent by next autumn.
- Ten retained clients on the books by year end.
- A podium finish at the regional race.

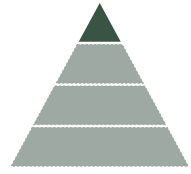
Naber's version

*By August 1976, Olympic gold in the 100m backstroke.
Mine: the training and the time. Not mine: who else
turns up, and how fast they are.*

THE TEST I could photograph it — and I've named the part that isn't mine.

"Marathon under 3:30" is a performance goal — the clock only measures you. "Podium at the regional race" is an end goal — it depends on who turns up. Same sport, same day, different level.

Dream goal



What's the bigger picture?

Taking a step back — what's important about that goal for you? · What inspired you to start, or to keep going?

Not really a goal at all — a vision that ignites action. Deliberately unmeasurable: if you can put a number on it, you have written an end goal. It is the only level that survives a bad quarter, and the one to audit once a year.

THE SENTENCE

I want a life where _____ ,
because _____ .

Examples

- I want to do work that people cross a city to be in the room for.
- I want to be the person my daughter comes to when it actually matters.
- I want to stop feeling like I'm faking it.

Naber's version

I want a life where I'm the best in the world at one thing — because I watched a man do it on television and it changed what I thought was possible.

THE TEST

My voice changes slightly when I say it out loud.

The “because” matters more than the first half. The first half is what you want; the second half is what it would mean. That's the part still standing in month nine.

One goal. Four sentences.

Work top down. You need to know where you're going before you can work out what today is for. Take ten minutes — this page is worth more than the rest of the workbook.

1 • Dream — What's the bigger picture?

I want a life where...

...because...

2 • End goal — What are you aiming to achieve?

By _____ ,

Mine to deliver

Not mine

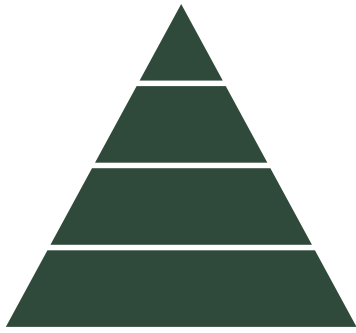
3 • Performance — What will you deliver?

By _____ , I will be operating at...

4 • Process — What actions will you take?

When...

...I will...



So — what's your thousandth of a second?

Naber couldn't control the medal. He could control the thousandth. And because he could control it, he got to feel like he was winning every day for four years, instead of finding out on one afternoon in Montreal whether any of it had been worth it.

You probably don't need more discipline. You need to stop staking your whole sense of yourself on the one level you were never in charge of, and start defining the two levels you were.

Your dream tells you why. Your end goal tells you where. But your standard and your process — those are the only two things you actually get to hold.

That is the whole pyramid. Four levels, four sentences, two of which are yours outright — and a weekly question simple enough to answer honestly on a Friday afternoon.

Want help holding them?

I coach entrepreneurs and leaders on exactly this: getting thoughts in order, setting a standard worth meeting, and committing to action that survives a bad month. If this workbook opened something up, let's talk it through properly.

Book a discovery session · chernyakov-coaching.com

Sources. The goals pyramid is from Sir John Whitmore, *Coaching for Performance* (5th ed., Ch. 10) — the framework is his, and the book is worth your time. Also drawn on: Timothy Gallwey, *The Inner Game of Tennis*; Gollwitzer & Sheeran (2006) on implementation intentions; Locke & Latham on goal-setting theory; Ordóñez, Schweitzer, Galinsky & Bazerman (2009), "Goals Gone Wild"; Will Storr, *The Science of Storytelling*; Prof. Brian Little on personal projects.

I'm a coach, not a clinician. Nothing here is therapy or medical advice.